Chapter Seventeen

State of Infrastructure

Infrastructure is a poorly understood concept. Essentially, whether publicly or privately built and operated, it is made up of physical assets or ‘facilities’ that provide ‘service’. Roads and railways are facilities that provide the service of transportation. Power plants provide electricity service. Airports provide service for the operation of airlines. Most infrastructure comprises physical facilities. However, in the IT age, there are technology-based facilities that are more virtual than physical. The Internet is the mother of technology-based facilities. Infrastructure services should be distinguished from services provided by human beings. Numerous services are provided by humans, directly or using machines and technology. A hairdresser doing your hair or an accountant who writes your company’s accounts are rendering what is typically and normally understood as service. These services are simply ‘services’. The difference between normal business services and infrastructure services is that businesses services are produced and provided by workers whereas infrastructure services are primarily provided by the facility created.

Infrastructure services are vital and intrinsic to development and growth. When habitations get connected by roads, the interactions of their inhabitants with the rest of the world improve. Transportation provided by roads enables people to reach workplaces, education centres, hospitals, airports, markets and numerous other providers of goods and services. Roads are essential for the development of unconnected areas. The same applies to other infrastructure services, whether electricity, telecom, the Internet or other infrastructure. The country or locality where infrastructure